

ANTONIO CROCCO, ed., *L'età dello Spirito e la fine dei tempi in Gioacchino da Fiore e nel Gioachimismo medievale*. Atti del II Congresso Internazionale di Studi Gioachimiti, 6-9 settembre 1984. S. Giovanni in Fiore, Italy: Centro Internazionale di Studi Gioachimiti, 1986. Paper. Pp. 533; 18 color and black-and-white photographs and plates. L 48,000.

The twelfth-century Calabrian abbot, exegete, visionary, and prophet Joachim of Fiore has become a small Italian industry, ready to take his place alongside Dante and Francis of Assisi to form the trinity of figures from the Italian Middle Ages who remain most vividly in the modern consciousness. Unlike Dante and Francis, however, Joachim has been a figure notoriously hard to summarize or evaluate. Giving a concise summary of Joachim and his place in medieval thought, western thought, and apocalyptic thought has pretty much remained a daunting and elusive task, beyond reaching general agreement that his influence is undeniable. This difficulty is underscored by a comment in the present volume by Bernard McGinn, a comment which can provide us with a useful entry into the book itself: his essay begins by suggesting that, contrary to the commonplace assumption, Joachim's theology of history cannot be easily reduced to a three-age or three-*status* view, because of its "complex and subtle interweaving of tradition and innovation containing many themes" (p. 220).

The structure of the book — whether itself influenced by Joachim or not — is likewise threefold, beginning with one series of essays ("Relazioni"), followed by a second ("Comunicazioni"), followed in turn and concluded by an elaborate description of the congress in Fiore at which these papers were presented, including a summary of events of the congress, several addresses, brief biographies of the medal winners (Henri de Lubac, Marjorie Reeves, Raoul Manselli, and Francesco Russo), and pictures (including one of the medals cast for the occasion). This threefold division, however, like Joachim's own three *status*, does not do justice to the complexity of this volume. It does not take into account that the twenty essays contained therein, written in a variety of languages, are different in fundamental ways. There are essays that are essentially little more than extended notes, and there are essays that are over sixty pages long. There are essays in French, English, German, and Italian and a concluding appendix in Latin. More important, it does not take into account that the essays vary greatly in terms of their approach to the subject, and indeed in their very definition of the subject, since both Joachim's works and that elusive phenomenon called Joachimism are equally subjects of the book.

The Joachim essays often present an explication of various texts, major and minor. The essays on Joachimism, on the other hand, deal with aspects that are somewhat harder to summarize or characterize, including essays on such varied subjects as the history of Joachim studies, the influence of Joachim on subsequent writers, and aspects of the manuscript tradition of Joachim texts (represented in turn by Kurt-Victor Selge, "Joachim von Fiore in der Geschichtsschreibung der letzten sechzig Jahre," pp. 29-54; Francesco d'Elia, "La 'terza età' giochimita e la 'Citta del Sole' di Tommaso Campanella," pp. 417-35; and E. Randolph Daniel, "The Manuscripts of the *Liber de concordia* and Early Joachimism," pp. 357-66).

This brief summary of the volume, then, must necessarily be seen as suggestive rather than exhaustive. Perhaps most important, the reader's attention needs to be called to those essays which attempt an explication of various texts of Joachim, essays which perform an especially valuable service because so much still needs to be done to make them available to a larger audience. (Only excerpts from his major works are available in English translation. Many of these works still exist only in sixteenth-century editions. And there are still works that remain unedited.) Therefore an essay

such as Edith Pasztor's ("Ideale del monachesimo ed età dello Spirito come realtà spirituale e forma d'Utopia," pp. 55–124) is particularly valuable for its careful explanation of a key idea of Joachim's thought as found and developed throughout his major works. Carefully and painstakingly done, this essay never takes the reader too far from the texts of Joachim, and it can appropriately serve as a corrective to those who would jump from a slim knowledge of his work to a grand theory about his influence. Thus part of the value of this volume is as a reminder of how much of the most basic kinds of research still needs to be done, as well as a caution against the huge generalizations which have often been the norm in Joachim studies.

Of the other sort of essays, those that deal with the larger and more elusive question of Joachimism, we can look to the McGinn essay, quoted above, as representative in that it, too, attempts to provide the same sort of useful corrective that is provided by a close reading of the texts of Joachim. McGinn's essay is an attempt to flesh out the various ways in which thinkers in the thirteenth century (and in the twentieth) have conspicuously failed to make a distinction between the thought of Joachim and those Joachites who have used him as a starting point for their own more or less independent systems. After a passage in which he shows what Thomas Aquinas has to say about the three-age theory of history, he wryly observes: "This may be an adequate answer to [the thirteenth-century Spiritual Franciscan] Gerard of Borgo San Donnino and the radicals, but it is not really a response to Joachim, who always insisted that the Son and the Holy Spirit work together during the time of the second *status*, and who never predicted a *nova lex Spiritus Sancti* . . ." (p. 228). For McGinn, the only thinker of the Middle Ages who used Joachim accurately and constructively was Bonaventure.

There are some disappointments in the volume. A minor quibble, but I do not think that Marjorie Reeves — the most important writer on Joachim in English — is represented by her best work. Her essay, "The Third Age: Dante's Debt to Gioacchino de Fiore," pp. 125–39, is more nuanced than her previous work on the relationship between Dante and Joachim, but it still contains assumptions about Dante that have been called into question, at least by American Dantists. There are (perhaps predictably) many typographical errors in the English essays. But this is a very rich volume, representing significant work by the world's best Joachim scholars, scholars who have spent decades contributing to our knowledge of this elusive yet monumental figure. This is not the work for those who want an introduction to Joachim. That task would be much better served by McGinn's 1985 study, *The Calabrian Abbot: Joachim of Fiore in the History of Western Thought*. But those who wish to be immersed in the richness and complexity of Joachim studies — and pointed to new lines of inquiry — will be well served by this volume. Its own richness and complexity are an apt mirror of its subject.

RONALD B. HERZMAN, State University College at Geneseo

JUDITH M. DAVIDOFF, *Beginning Well: Framing Fictions in Late Middle English Poetry*. Rutherford, N.J.; Madison, Wis.; and Teaneck, N.J.: Fairleigh Dickinson University Press; London and Toronto: Associated University Presses, 1988. Pp. 242; 3 figures. \$35.

A surprising number of medieval poems employ the convention of "framing" a moral lesson with a brief narrative that describes the poet-narrator's foray into a natural setting, where he either encounters a guide or becomes the passive and private observer of a debate or similar event. These poems encompass *chanson d'aventure* lyrics, love visions, philosophical visions, debate poems, and other dream-vision ana-